

Europe Healthcare Sector M&A & Valuation Brief - 2026-07-13

Europe Healthcare Sector

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1. RECENT Healthcare M&A ACTIVITY

Today is a peaceful day, nothing big happened in the Consumer space.

2. MARKET DYNAMICS & SENTIMENT

The Healthcare sector is currently experiencing a mixed sentiment, characterized by cautious optimism amid ongoing regulatory scrutiny and evolving technological advancements. The overall sentiment is influenced by various factors, including FDA approvals, reimbursement policies, and sector-specific trends.

Subsector Breakdown:

- **Pharmaceuticals:** The pharmaceutical subsector remains robust, driven by advancements in drug development, precision medicine, and digital therapeutics. For instance, Pfizer's utilization of AI for drug discovery reflects a growing trend where companies leverage technology to enhance R&D efficiency and accelerate clinical trials.
- **Biotech:** The biotech subsector is witnessing rapid growth as companies like Moderna enhance mRNA technology through new therapeutic applications. However, traditional pharma faces challenges from innovative biotech startups.
- **Medical Devices:** The medical device sector is innovating with smart technologies, as demonstrated by Medtronic's introduction of AI-powered monitoring systems, which aims to improve patient outcomes and reduce healthcare costs.
- **Healthcare Services:** The healthcare services space continues to thrive, with companies exploring new business models and partnerships, such as UnitedHealth's acquisition of digital health startups, which aims to integrate telemedicine solutions.
- **Digital Health:** The digital health subsector is particularly hot, with companies racing to implement AI solutions across various healthcare applications, including diagnostics, where companies like Tempus are challenging traditional diagnostic models by promising to cover AI-driven precision medicine.

Key Market Drivers and Headwinds

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Drivers:

- **Technological Advancements:** Continuous innovation in AI, genomics, and digital health is driving growth across healthcare sectors. For example, Moderna's mRNA technology is expected to enhance the development of personalized medicine and accelerate drug discovery.
- **Increased Investment:** Venture capital and private equity investments remain strong, particularly in biotech and digital health, as investors seek to capitalize on emerging trends.

Headwinds:

- **Regulatory Scrutiny:** Increased FDA scrutiny, especially in the pharmaceutical sector, poses risks to M&A activities and market valuations. Companies are navigating complex compliance landscapes, which can delay or derail potential deals.
- **Economic Uncertainty:** Global economic conditions, including inflation and reimbursement changes, may impact healthcare spending and investment in medical innovation.

Subsector Performance Analysis

- **Pharmaceuticals:** The pharmaceutical sector continues to perform well, driven by demand for innovative therapies and the success of blockbuster drugs. Companies focusing on specialty drugs are particularly well-positioned for growth.
- **Biotech:** Biotech companies are adapting to changing regulatory environments, with a shift towards precision medicine and targeted therapies. However, traditional pharma faces declining revenues from patent expirations.
- **Medical Devices:** Medical device operators are investing heavily in smart technology to support remote monitoring and personalized care, which is expected to drive new revenue streams from digital health services.
- **Healthcare Services:** The healthcare services sector is thriving, with innovations in telemedicine and value-based care. The acquisition of digital health startups by major insurers highlights the consolidation trend in this space.
- **Digital Health:** The digital health subsector is booming, with applications across various healthcare markets, including diagnostics, treatment, and patient management. Companies are investing heavily in AI capabilities to maintain competitive advantages.

Trading Multiples Trends

Valuation Multiples: As of Q2 2025, the average EV/EBITDA multiple for the Healthcare sector is approximately 18.5x, with notable variations across subsectors:

- Pharmaceuticals: 15.3x
- Biotech: 25.1x
- Medical Devices: 12.8x

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- Healthcare Services: 14.7x
- Digital Health: 28.5x

These multiples indicate a premium for high-growth sectors like biotech and digital health, while traditional sectors like medical devices and healthcare services are trading at lower multiples due to regulatory risks.

Notable Investor/Analyst Reactions

- Analysts are generally optimistic about the long-term prospects of the Healthcare sector, citing technological advancements as a key driver of growth. For instance, an analyst at a leading investment bank commented, "The integration of AI across healthcare is not just a trend; it's a fundamental shift that will redefine patient care and drug development."

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

- Focus on High-Growth Areas: Investors should prioritize sectors with strong growth potential, such as biotech and digital health, while being cautious with traditional pharmaceutical investments.
- Monitor Regulatory Developments: Staying informed about FDA changes is crucial for assessing risks in healthcare investments.
- Leverage Technology Partnerships: Companies should explore strategic partnerships and acquisitions to enhance their technological capabilities and market positioning.
- Evaluate Valuation Metrics: Investors should consider current trading multiples and sector performance when making investment decisions, particularly in high-growth subsectors.

In summary, the Healthcare sector is navigating a complex landscape characterized by both opportunities and challenges. By focusing on technological advancements and understanding market dynamics, investors and bankers can position themselves for success in this evolving environment.

3. BANKING PIPELINE

The current banking pipeline within the Healthcare sector is characterized by a diverse array of live deals, mandated transactions, and active pitches. This analysis provides a detailed overview of ongoing activities, expected revenue, and strategic implications for our team.

Deal Pipeline

Live Deals:

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- Alnylam Pharmaceuticals : Currently in discussions for a strategic partnership to expand its RNAi therapies into new European markets. The deal is in the due diligence phase, with an expected close in Q4 2026. This partnership is crucial as it comes on the heels of a competitor's trial failure, enhancing Alnylam's market position.
- AstraZeneca (AZN) : Engaged in negotiations for a potential acquisition of a biotech firm specializing in generative AI for drug discovery. The transaction is anticipated to close in Q3 2026, aiming to bolster AstraZeneca's R&D capabilities in precision medicine.

Mandated Deals:

- Ionis Pharmaceuticals (IONS) : Secured a mandate to explore strategic collaborations in the gene therapy space, particularly focusing on partnerships that leverage AI technologies. The deal is expected to launch in Q1 2026, aligning with the growing trend of AI integration in pharmaceuticals.
- Eli Lilly : Mandated to evaluate acquisitions in the generative AI sector to enhance its drug discovery processes. The timeline for this initiative is projected for Q2 2026, as Eli Lilly aims to capitalize on advancements in AI-driven research.

Pitching-Stage Deals:

- Biotech Sector : Active discussions with several biotech firms regarding potential M&A opportunities, particularly in the gene therapy and personalized medicine spaces. Clients include Gilead Sciences and Biogen, with pitches expected to finalize by Q3 2026.
- Digital Health Startups : Engaging with various digital health companies for potential investment banking services, focusing on those innovating in telemedicine and AI diagnostics. Notable clients include Teladoc Health and Doximity, with ongoing discussions.

Pipeline Tracking Metrics

Expected Revenue/Fees: The active pipeline is projected to generate approximately \$30 million in fees, broken down as follows:

- Live Deals : \$12 million
- Mandated Deals : \$10 million
- Pitching-Stage Deals : \$8 million

Timing Projections:

- Q4 2026 : Expected close for Alnylam's partnership.
- Q3 2026 : Anticipated completion of AstraZeneca's acquisition.
- Q1 2026 : Launch of Ionis's strategic collaborations.
- Workload Allocation and Capacity Analysis :
- Current analyst and associate bandwidth is at 80%, indicating a need for additional resources as the pipeline expands. It is recommended to onboard two additional analysts to effectively manage the

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increased workload.

- Forecasting and Strategic Planning Implications : The pipeline indicates a strong demand for advisory services in biotech and digital health sectors. Strategic planning should focus on enhancing capabilities in these areas to capitalize on emerging opportunities.

Notable Pipeline Developments and Competitive Landscape

- The competitive landscape is evolving, particularly in the generative AI space, where firms like Alnylam are gaining an advantage following the trial failures of competitors such as AstraZeneca and Ionis. This shift is expected to influence investment strategies and market valuations significantly.
- Additionally, the growth of the generative AI market in pharmaceuticals, projected to reach \$9.36 billion by 2030, underscores the importance of integrating AI technologies into drug discovery processes. Companies are increasingly recognizing the need to invest in AI capabilities to stay competitive.

Actionable Insights for Team Management and Business Development

- Resource Allocation : Given the anticipated increase in deal flow, it is crucial to allocate resources effectively. Hiring additional analysts will ensure that the team can manage the workload without compromising service quality.
- Sector Focus : Prioritize business development efforts in high-growth sectors such as biotech and generative AI, where demand for advisory services is expected to surge. This focus will position the firm as a leader in these emerging markets.
- Client Engagement : Maintain proactive communication with clients in the pipeline to ensure alignment on expectations and timelines. Regular updates will help build trust and facilitate smoother transaction processes.

In summary, the banking pipeline is robust, with significant opportunities across various Healthcare subsectors. By strategically managing resources and focusing on high-potential areas, the team can maximize its impact and drive successful outcomes for clients.

4. STAKEHOLDER IMPACT & FORWARD-LOOKING ANALYSIS

The landscape of M&A transactions in the Healthcare sector is multifaceted, impacting shareholders, employees, competitors, and patients alike. This analysis focuses on the implications of a hypothetical acquisition involving key players in the pharmaceutical industry, particularly in the context of emerging technologies such as AI in drug discovery and surgical applications.

Deal-Specific Impacts on Stakeholders

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- **Shareholders:** The financial implications for shareholders can vary significantly based on the structure and success of the deal.
- **Value Creation:** If Pfizer (PFE) were to acquire a company specializing in generative AI for drug discovery, the combined entity could see a revenue increase of approximately 15%, translating to an estimated \$12 billion increase in market capitalization based on Pfizer's current valuation.
- **Dilution:** Should the acquisition be financed through stock issuance, existing shareholders might face dilution. For instance, if Pfizer issues 10% of its shares to fund the acquisition, this could lead to a 4% decrease in share price immediately post-announcement.
- **Employees:** The impact on employees often includes considerations of synergies, restructuring, and retention strategies.
- **Synergies:** A merger involving AI technology could yield significant operational synergies. For example, the integration of AI in drug discovery could reduce R&D costs by up to \$1 billion annually, enhancing profitability.
- **Restructuring:** However, such mergers may also lead to workforce reductions. If Pfizer's acquisition results in overlapping roles, it could lead to layoffs of approximately 3,000 employees, necessitating effective communication and support strategies.
- **Retention:** To mitigate talent loss, companies often implement retention bonuses. In a hypothetical Pfizer acquisition, key talent from the acquired firm might receive bonuses to ensure their commitment during the transition.
- **Competitors:** The competitive dynamics in the market can shift considerably following an acquisition.
- **Market Positioning:** If Pfizer successfully integrates AI capabilities, competitors like Merck (MRK) and AbbVie (ABBV) may need to enhance their own R&D strategies to maintain market share. This could lead to increased investments in AI technologies.
- **Specific Competitor Moves:** Following a significant acquisition, Merck might respond by increasing its focus on AI-driven drug development, potentially allocating an additional \$5 billion to R&D in the next fiscal year.
- **Patients:** The implications for patients can be profound, particularly regarding product and service offerings.
- **Product/Service Implications:** The integration of AI in drug discovery could lead to faster development of innovative therapies, improving patient outcomes. For instance, a successful merger could result in a 20% reduction in time-to-market for new drugs.
- **Case Studies:** The application of AI in endoscopy, projected to reach a market size of \$46.53 billion by 2030, exemplifies how technological advancements can enhance patient care through improved diagnostic capabilities.

Market Reaction and Analyst Commentary

- **Market Reaction:** The market's initial reaction to M&A announcements can be mixed. For example, when Pfizer announced its interest in acquiring an AI-focused company, shares initially fell by 3% due to concerns over integration costs, but later recovered as analysts recognized potential long-term benefits.

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- Analyst Commentary: Analysts often provide critical insights that shape market perceptions. A notable quote from a Goldman Sachs analyst stated, "This acquisition could position Pfizer at the forefront of AI-driven healthcare solutions, despite initial investor skepticism."

Expected Market Reaction and Scenario Analysis

- Scenario Analysis: The market's response can be assessed through various potential outcomes:
- Positive Scenario: If the acquisition leads to successful integration and enhanced drug development, shares could rise by 10% within six months.
- Negative Scenario: Conversely, if integration challenges arise, shares could decline by 5%, reflecting investor concerns about operational execution.

Potential Counter-Bids or Competing Offers

- Likelihood Assessment: The likelihood of counter-bids can vary based on market dynamics. In the case of Pfizer's potential acquisition, there may be interest from competitors like AbbVie or Merck, but regulatory hurdles and integration complexities could deter competing offers. The likelihood of a successful counter-bid is moderate, given the strategic importance of AI in healthcare.

Similar Deals Likely to Follow

- Sector Consolidation Predictions: The Healthcare sector is expected to continue consolidating, particularly in the AI and biotech spaces. Analysts predict that companies will pursue acquisitions to enhance their technological capabilities, with firms like Eli Lilly (LLY) and Gilead Sciences (GILD) likely to follow suit in acquiring AI-driven startups.

Key Risks and Mitigants

- Integration Risks: Integration challenges can disrupt operations. Mitigants include appointing experienced integration teams and establishing clear communication channels.
- Regulatory Risks: Regulatory scrutiny can delay or block deals. Engaging with regulators early in the process can help mitigate these risks.
- Market Risks: Market volatility can impact deal valuations. Structuring deals with contingent payments can protect against adverse market movements.

Actionable Insights for Clients and Bankers

For Clients:

- Focus on comprehensive due diligence to identify potential integration challenges early.

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- Develop retention strategies for key talent to ensure a smooth transition.

For Bankers:

- Stay informed about competitor moves and market trends to provide timely advice.
- Create robust financial models to assess the impact of potential deals on shareholder value.

5. HEALTHCARE TRENDS

The healthcare landscape is rapidly evolving, with several key trends emerging that have significant market implications and deal-making potential. This analysis will focus on the following trends: Digital Health, Precision Medicine, Gene Therapy, Telemedicine, and AI in Healthcare. Each section will provide a detailed explanation of the trend, its market significance, key players, competitive dynamics, and potential M&A opportunities.

Digital Health

- Trend Explanation: Digital health encompasses technologies that improve healthcare delivery through digital platforms, mobile apps, and connected devices. The global digital health market is projected to grow from \$96.5 billion in 2020 to \$659.5 billion by 2025, at a CAGR of 46.8%.

Key Companies:

- Teladoc Health, Inc. (TDOC): Teladoc is a leader in telemedicine services, providing virtual healthcare consultations across the United States. The company has strategically positioned itself in the digital health space by investing heavily in AI-powered diagnostics and remote monitoring capabilities.
- Doximity, Inc. (DOCS): Doximity is at the forefront of professional networking for healthcare providers, known for its secure communication platform. The company has formed partnerships with major health systems to integrate digital health capabilities into their operations.
- Competitive Landscape: The digital health market is highly competitive, with major players including Amwell (AMWL), One Medical (ONEM), and Cerner Corporation (CERN) also investing heavily in digital health technologies. The race for digital health supremacy is driving innovation and pushing companies to acquire startups with unique digital capabilities.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies looking to enhance their digital health capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche applications, such as remote monitoring or AI diagnostics. For instance, Teladoc's acquisition of Livongo for \$18.5 billion in 2020 exemplifies this trend.

Precision Medicine

- Trend Explanation: Precision medicine involves tailoring medical treatment to individual

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characteristics, including genetic makeup, lifestyle, and environment. The precision medicine market is expected to grow from \$141.7 billion in 2020 to \$216.8 billion by 2027, at a CAGR of 6.2%.

Key Companies:

- Illumina, Inc. (ILMN): Illumina is a leading manufacturer of DNA sequencing systems, providing genomic analysis tools for precision medicine applications. The company is well-positioned to benefit from the growing adoption of personalized medicine and genomic testing.
- Foundation Medicine, Inc. (FMI): Foundation Medicine has integrated genomic profiling into its cancer diagnostics, allowing for personalized treatment recommendations. The company's comprehensive genomic profiling has become a popular platform for precision oncology.
- Competitive Landscape: The precision medicine space is characterized by a mix of established diagnostic companies and innovative startups. Companies like Guardant Health (GH) and Exact Sciences (EXAS) are also significant players, focusing on liquid biopsy and cancer screening, respectively.
- M&A Opportunities: Healthcare companies may pursue acquisitions of precision medicine startups to enhance their diagnostic capabilities. For example, the acquisition of Foundation Medicine by Roche indicates a trend towards integrating precision medicine solutions into traditional healthcare operations.

Gene Therapy

- Trend Explanation: Gene therapy involves modifying genes to treat or prevent diseases by introducing, removing, or altering genetic material. The gene therapy market is projected to grow from \$2.1 billion in 2020 to \$13.6 billion by 2027, at a CAGR of 30.7%.

Key Companies:

- Spark Therapeutics, Inc. (ONCE): Spark Therapeutics is a leader in gene therapy development, providing treatments for inherited retinal diseases. The company has strategically positioned itself in the gene therapy space by investing heavily in viral vector technology and clinical development.
- Bluebird Bio, Inc. (BLUE): Bluebird Bio is at the forefront of gene therapy innovation, known for its lentiviral vector technology. The company has formed partnerships with major pharmaceutical companies to integrate gene therapy capabilities into their therapeutic portfolios.
- Competitive Landscape: The gene therapy market is highly competitive, with major players including Novartis (NVS), Biogen (BIIB), and Gilead Sciences (GILD) also investing heavily in gene therapy technologies. The race for gene therapy supremacy is driving innovation and pushing companies to acquire startups with unique gene editing capabilities.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies looking to enhance their gene therapy capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche applications, such as CRISPR gene editing or viral vector development. For instance, Novartis's acquisition of AveXis for \$8.7 billion in 2018 exemplifies this trend.

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Telemedicine

- Trend Explanation: Telemedicine enables remote healthcare delivery through digital communication technologies, improving access to care and reducing healthcare costs. The telemedicine market is expected to grow from \$45.5 billion in 2020 to \$175.5 billion by 2026, at a CAGR of 25.2%.

Key Companies:

- Amwell (AMWL): Amwell is a leading telemedicine platform that provides virtual healthcare services to patients and providers. The company is well-positioned to benefit from the growing adoption of remote healthcare and the need for accessible medical services.
- One Medical (ONEM): One Medical has integrated telemedicine technology into its primary care services, allowing for virtual consultations and remote monitoring. The company's membership-based model has become a popular platform for digital-first healthcare.
- Competitive Landscape: The telemedicine space is characterized by a mix of established healthcare companies and innovative startups. Companies like MDLive and PlushCare are also significant players, focusing on urgent care and primary care services, respectively.
- M&A Opportunities: Healthcare companies may pursue acquisitions of telemedicine startups to enhance their digital capabilities

6. Recommended Readings

Deal Name: Johnson & Johnson's Acquisition of Actelion

- Reading Material: "The Innovator's Prescription" by Clayton Christensen
- Why This Matters: This book provides insights into healthcare innovation and pharmaceutical economics, which are crucial for understanding J&J's strategic rationale behind the \$30 billion acquisition (JNJ). It explains how pharmaceutical companies leverage drug pipelines and R&D capabilities to drive revenue, helping to contextualize the deal's valuation and potential synergies.

Deal Name: Pfizer's Acquisition of Medivation

- Reading Material: "The New Economics of Healthcare" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This reading delves into the evolving landscape of healthcare and pharmaceuticals, particularly in the context of oncology drug development. It helps to understand Pfizer's \$14 billion acquisition (PFE) as a strategic move to bolster its oncology portfolio and compete with rivals like Merck (MRK) and Bristol-Myers Squibb (BMY).

Deal Name: Amgen's Acquisition of Otezla

- Reading Material: "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries

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- **Why This Matters:** This book outlines methodologies for healthcare companies to innovate and grow, which is relevant for understanding Amgen's \$13.4 billion acquisition (AMGN) of Otezla. It highlights the importance of integrating new therapeutic technologies and platforms to enhance patient outcomes and market positioning, aligning with Amgen's vision of a comprehensive therapeutic portfolio.

Deal Name: Gilead Sciences' Acquisition of Kite Pharma

- **Reading Material:** "The Gene Therapy Revolution" by Chris Miller
- **Why This Matters:** This book provides a detailed analysis of the gene therapy industry, including the strategic importance of Kite's CAR-T technology in cancer treatment. Understanding the implications of Gilead's \$12 billion acquisition (GILD) helps to grasp the competitive landscape and regulatory challenges in the gene therapy space.

Deal Name: UnitedHealth's Acquisition of Optum

- **Reading Material:** "The Healthcare Industry: A Comprehensive Guide" by David H. Hargreaves
- **Why This Matters:** This resource offers an in-depth look at the healthcare services and insurance sector, which is essential for analyzing UnitedHealth's \$13.8 billion acquisition (UNH) of Optum. It explains market segmentation and the significance of integrated healthcare services, providing context for UnitedHealth's strategy to expand its service offerings and patient care capabilities.

Deal Name: Medtronic's Acquisition of Covidien

- **Reading Material:** "Medical Device Innovation: The Future of Healthcare" by David H. Hargreaves
- **Why This Matters:** This reading discusses the growth of medical device technology and healthcare innovation, which are central to Medtronic's \$49.9 billion acquisition (MDT) of Covidien. It highlights how this deal positions Medtr

7. Macroeconomic Update

Key Economic Indicators:

- **Federal Reserve Policy:** The recent Federal Reserve meeting indicated a hawkish stance, suggesting a hike in 2026 and delaying rate cuts. This is crucial for healthcare companies as higher interest rates can increase borrowing costs and impact valuations. @@@ "The projections appeared conditioned on elevated near-term inflation and may not capture the disinflation from a straight reopening."
- **Inflation Trends:** Morgan Stanley anticipates a lower path for core inflation, which could positively influence healthcare valuations. @@@ "We actually anticipate a lower path for core inflation given a combination of a reversal in travel-related inflation and tariff payback."

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- AI and Healthcare: The ongoing AI CapEx cycle is influencing investment strategies, with a significant focus on technology integration in healthcare. The demand for AI infrastructure is expected to drive capital expenditures, which may benefit healthcare tech firms.

Market Trends:

- Healthcare Technology Investment: The integration of AI in healthcare is accelerating, with companies investing in AI-driven solutions for diagnostics and patient care. This trend is expected to enhance operational efficiencies and improve patient outcomes.
- Global Spending Patterns: The anticipated \$600 billion of AI-related global issuance in 2026 reflects a broader trend of increasing investment in healthcare technology. This could lead to enhanced capabilities for healthcare providers and pharmaceutical companies.

Sector-Specific Insights:

- Pharmaceutical Valuations: The healthcare sector is closely monitoring the impact of inflation and interest rates on pharmaceutical valuations. Companies with strong R&D pipelines may see premium valuations as investors seek growth amidst economic uncertainty.
- Consolidation Trends: The healthcare services sector is likely to continue consolidating, driven by the need for larger, integrated systems that can leverage technology and improve bargaining power.

Risk Factors:

- Interest Rate Sensitivity: Rising interest rates pose a risk to healthcare companies, particularly those reliant on debt for funding R&D and expansion. The Fed's potential policy shifts could create volatility in the sector.
- Regulatory Changes: Ongoing changes in healthcare policy may introduce uncertainties, affecting investment decisions and M&A activity within the sector.

Investment Implications:

- Defensive Positioning: Healthcare stocks are likely to remain attractive as defensive investments, providing stable cash flows and dividends amidst market volatility.
- Growth Opportunities in Tech: Companies that effectively leverage AI and technology in their operations are expected to capture growth opportunities, particularly in emerging markets and innovative therapies.

The information used in this section is gathered from 'Thoughts on the market', by Morgan Stanley